

Princess Seam Midi Dress

Complete Construction Guide

Half Scale – Size 16

Model Seam Allowance: ¼"

DESIGN OVERVIEW

This dress features a chiffon outer bodice with a satin underlayer, a princess-seamed bodice finished with black piping, a scoop neckline finished with black cording, a functional center-front closure with satin rouleau loops and fabric-covered buttons, short chiffon puff sleeves with sleeve bands, ivory ribbon bows at the shoulders, a satin underskirt with a chiffon overlay, a gathered waist, black piping at the waist seam, and an invisible zipper at the center back.

MATERIAL PREPARATION

For the bodice, cut two pieces of each pattern piece (one in lining material-stain, one in fashion fabric-chiffon) and place the chiffon directly over the satin for the Front Center Bodice (2), Front Side Bodice (2), Center Back Bodice (2), and Side Back Bodice (2). Match all edges carefully and baste around the entire perimeter within the seam allowance. After basting, treat each piece as one layer. The sleeves are constructed from chiffon only and do not have a satin underlayer. The sleeve pieces consist of Sleeve (2) and Sleeve Band (2). The skirt is constructed separately as a satin layer and a chiffon layer. Each layer consists of a front skirt cut on the fold and a back skirt cut on the fold.

PART ONE: CONSTRUCTING THE BODICE

FRONT BODICE CONSTRUCTION

Step 1: Apply front princess seam piping by basting piping to the princess seam edges of both front center bodice pieces using a zipper foot. Align the raw edge of the piping with the raw edge of the fabric and ensure the piping cord faces inward toward the garment.

Step 2: Sew the front princess seams by pinning the front side bodice pieces to the front center bodice pieces. Match notches carefully and sew directly beside the piping cord using a zipper foot. Repeat for both front bodice sections and press seam allowances toward the side front pieces.

BACK BODICE CONSTRUCTION

Step 3: Apply piping to the princess seam edges of both center back pieces using a zipper foot.

Step 4: Attach the side back bodice pieces, matching notches carefully. Sew beside the piping cord and press seam allowances toward the side back pieces.

CREATE LEFT AND RIGHT BODICE HALVES

Step 5: Join the left front bodice to the left back bodice at the shoulder seam and press the seam open.

Step 6: Join the right front bodice to the right back bodice at the shoulder seam and press the seam open. At this point there should be a left bodice half and a right bodice half connected only at the shoulders, with side seams remaining open.

APPLY CORDING

Note: The armholes, side seams, and waist edge do not receive cording.

Step 7: Cut one continuous length of cording. Beginning at the bottom of the left center front, apply the cording continuously around the left center front edge, left neckline, left shoulder edge, and left center back edge, ending at the bottom of the left center back. Use a zipper foot, clip neckline curves as necessary, and avoid stretching the cording.

Step 8: Finish the left cording by turning the edge finish to the inside, wrapping neatly around the cording, stitching close to the cord, and pressing carefully.

Step 9: Repeat the process for the right bodice half.

Step 10: Finish the right cording in the same manner. The cording should now outline the entire front opening, neckline, both shoulder edges, and the entire center back opening.

JOIN BODICE HALVES

Step 11: Match the left and right bodice halves and sew the side seams. Press the seams open.

FRONT CLOSURE

Step 12: Determine the front overlap by laying the bodice flat and ensuring both center front edges align evenly.

Step 13: Mark evenly spaced button placements beginning approximately ½ inch below the neckline and ending approximately 1 inch above the waist seam. Transfer markings to the opposite edge for the loops.

Step 14: Create satin rouleau tubing by cutting satin bias strips approximately $\frac{3}{4}$ inch wide. Fold lengthwise with right sides together, stitch approximately inch from the folded edge, trim the seam allowance, turn right side out, and press lightly.

Step 15: Cut the tubing into equal sections to create rouleau loops. Test one loop before cutting all remaining loops.

Step 16: Fold each section into a loop, position on the marked locations, and baste securely.

Step 17: Hand stitch the loop ends securely to the inside of the center front edge.

Step 18: Attach the fabric-covered buttons, test each loop, and ensure the closure lies flat and functions smoothly.

CONSTRUCT SLEEVES

Step 19: Sew the sleeve seams using French seams. First sew with wrong sides together, trim the seam allowance, turn right sides together, and sew again to fully enclose the raw edges.

Step 20: Sew two rows of gathering stitches around the sleeve cap.

Step 21: Sew two rows of gathering stitches around the lower sleeve edge.

Step 22: Fold sleeve bands in half, sew the short ends, press the seam open, fold wrong sides together, and press.

Step 23: Gather the lower sleeve edge to fit the band, distribute gathers evenly, attach the band, and press the seam allowance toward the sleeve.

INSERT SLEEVES

Step 24: Insert the sleeves into the armholes, matching underarm seams, shoulder seams, and sleeve notches. Adjust gathers evenly, pin thoroughly, sew the armhole seam, and press toward the bodice.

PART TWO: CONSTRUCTING THE SKIRT

CONSTRUCT SATIN SKIRT

Step 25: Join the satin skirt front and back at the side seams and press seams open.

CONSTRUCT CHIFFON SKIRT

Step 26: Join the chiffon skirt front and back at the side seams using French seams when possible and press carefully.

COMBINE SKIRT LAYERS

Step 27: Place the chiffon skirt over the satin skirt, align all markings, and baste together at the waistline.

Step 28: Sew two rows of gathering stitches through both layers at the waist.

APPLY WAIST PIPING

Step 29: Baste piping around the entire lower edge of the bodice using a zipper foot and join piping ends neatly.

ATTACH SKIRT TO BODICE

Step 30: Gather the skirt to match the bodice circumference and distribute fullness evenly.

Step 31: Attach the skirt to the bodice with the waist piping sandwiched between the layers. Sew close to the piping cord and press the seam allowance upward into the bodice.

INSERT ZIPPER

Step 32: Button the center front, align center back edges, insert the invisible zipper from neckline through skirt, match the waist seam precisely, and press carefully.

HEM

Step 33: Allow the dress to hang overnight so the chiffon can settle naturally.

Step 34: Hem the satin layer by turning up ¼ inch, pressing, and stitching.

Step 35: Hem the chiffon layer with a narrow rolled hem and allow it to hang approximately ¼–½ inch below the satin layer.

PART THREE: FINISHING TOUCHES

ATTACH BOWS

Step 36: Create matching ivory ribbon bows and shape evenly.

Step 37: Position bows at the shoulder seam directly above the sleeve cap and hand sew securely.

FINAL PRESSING

Step 38: Press the princess seams, shoulder seams, side seams, neckline, center front closure, waist seam, and sleeve bands. Lightly steam the chiffon sleeves, skirt gathers, and chiffon overlay. Avoid flattening the puff sleeves or ribbon bows.